

March

11

COVID-19 pandemic

2020

With the number of cases rapidly increasing worldwide, the World Health Organization (WHO) officially declared the outbreak of new disease COVID-19 a pandemic and advised countries to act urgently. This highly contagious disease would go on to infect millions of people.

Born this day

1926 Ralph David Abernathy, Black American civil rights leader. He worked with Martin Luther King, Jr to end racial segregation on public transport in the USA with the Montgomery bus boycotts.

2011

Fukushima disaster

A devastating earthquake off the coast of Japan triggered a huge tsunami that destroyed or damaged many buildings and killed around 20,000 people. At the Fukushima nuclear reactor, the quake caused radioactive materials to be released into the air and ocean in the worst nuclear disaster since the accident at Chernobyl, Ukraine, in 1986.

Also on this day

1888 A severe blizzard called the **Great White Hurricane** brought transport systems to a halt and interrupted communication in and around New York City, USA.

1985 **Mikhail Gorbachev** was chosen as the new **leader** of the Soviet Union. He made several political and economic reforms that would, in part, lead to the collapse of the communist state.

2004 The **Spanish rail network in Madrid** was targeted by Islamic extremists who detonated 10 bombs on four trains, killing 191 civilians.

1967 **Animals in danger**

The first endangered species list was published by the US Department of the Interior, which was tasked with protecting rare wildlife in the country. The list featured 78 species at risk of extinction, including the grizzly bear, Florida manatee, American alligator, and bald eagle.

